



small business
development

Department:
Small Business Development
REPUBLIC OF SOUTH AFRICA



**9 April 2026 | East London,
Eastern Cape**

*'From Dialogue to Action: Together
Driving Inclusive MSME Growth'*

MSME & COOPERATIVES
**INCLUSIVE
GROWTH**
FORUM



From Dialogue to Action: Together Driving Inclusive MSME Growth"

Time	Activities	Lead	Outcomes
09:00 – 10:00	Registration, Welcome Tea & Exhibition Opening • Guest arrival • MSME Exhibition / Pop Up Market opens • Promotion of MSME & Cooperative Success Stories • Networking facilitated by SEDFA officials	SEDFA Marketing	• Seamless accreditation of all delegates. • Full activation of MSME Exhibition & Pop Up Market showcasing high potential enterprises. • Visibility for MSME & cooperative success stories to inspire replication and ecosystem learning.
10:00 – 10:05	Orientation • Set the context for the meeting • Confirm agenda • Outline Housekeeping messages	Programme Director Mr Simphiwe Somdyala ECRDA CEO	Common understanding of the objectives, flow, and expected engagements of the day.
10:05 – 10:10	Welcoming Remarks • Political endorsement of the forum	Buffalo City Metropolitan Municipality - Executive Mayor Councillor Princess Faku	
10:10 – 10:20	Opening Remarks • Purpose of the Forum • Strategic positioning of SEDFA	Chairperson of the Social, Ethics & Transformation Committee of Board - Ms Xoliswa Daku	• Shared understanding of the forum's purpose and strategic relevance. • Clear articulation of SEDFA's role as the national MSME ecosystem coordinator and enabler.
10:20 – 10:30	Message of Support • Political endorsement and commitment to MSME & Cooperative development • Introduction of Minister	Member of the Executive Council - Economic Development, Environmental Affairs and Tourism Ms Nonkqubela Pieters	Reinforced commitment to provincial and district-led MSME & Cooperative development.



Time	Activities	Lead	Outcomes
10:30 – 11:00	Keynote Address • National MSME Cooperatives priorities • Policy alignment & shared commitments	Minister of Small Business Development Ms Stella Tembisa Ndabeni	Reinforcement of government's commitment to MSME and cooperative development
11:00 – 11:20	• Presentation of the Concept Note & National Implementation Roadmap	UNISA's Bureau of Market Research (BMR) Prof D. Tustin BMR CEO	• Evidence-based overview of MSME ecosystem challenges and opportunities. • Establishment of a shared analytical foundation for breakaway sessions, the Compact & Commitment Charter.
11:20 – 11:35 Refreshment Break & Exhibition Walkabout			
11:35 – 13:35	Breakaway Session 1 – Access to Finance Identifying practical solutions to improve MSME access to funding. The session highlights the structural challenges, alternative financing opportunities, capacity building needs, and potential institutional partnerships that could strengthen financial inclusion for small businesses.	Lead : SEDFA – Chief Investment Officer Mr Richard Manzini Moderator & Rapporteur Mr Thabang Hleza – Old Mutual Masisizane Fund – Executive Head: Investment Operations	• Develop tailored financial products with banking and non banking partners that reduce collateral requirements and accommodate MSMEs with limited credit history. • Expand accessible alternative financing mechanisms—including microfinance, crowdfunding, and government backed loan programmes—through coordinated national and district level partnerships. • Strengthen MSME financial literacy programmes, including loan readiness training, credit management, bookkeeping, and funding application support, delivered through SEDFA and ecosystem partners. • Promote digital finance tools and platforms to make funding more accessible, transparent, and efficient for small enterprises, especially in rural and township economies. • Integrate district level finance support desks into the MSME ecosystem to improve awareness of available products and facilitate successful funding applications. • Generate actionable inputs for the Compact, including commitments from financial institutions to adjust lending criteria, expand outreach, and support MSME pipeline development.



Time	Activities	Lead	Outcomes
11:35 – 13:35	Breakaway Session 2 – Access to Markets Explores practical strategies to help small businesses overcome barriers to entering and expanding within local, district, and national markets. The discussion focuses on structural constraints, ecosystem coordination, and the types of support required to enhance market readiness for MSMEs.	Lead : SEDFA – Group Executive: BDS Mr Siphon Ngcai Moderator & Rapporteur Mr Luvuyo Mosana ECSECC CEO	• Reduce structural barriers to market entry by simplifying procurement processes, improving compliance support, and addressing certification and logistical challenges that currently exclude MSMEs from local, district, and national value chains. • Strengthen MSME visibility and competitiveness by expanding access to digital sales platforms, e commerce tools, branding and packaging support, and market intelligence services. • Formalise partnerships with government, large corporates, and industry associations to unlock supplier development opportunities, support local sourcing, and improve MSME participation in public and private procurement. • Leverage existing platforms—such as procurement portals, industry clusters, chambers, export councils, and ecosystem forums—to scale MSME market reach and provide continuous exposure to new buyers. • Build MSME market readiness through targeted capacity building programmes on pricing strategies, quality standards, contract management, marketing, and customer acquisition. • Feed actionable insights into the Ecosystem Compact, shaping commitments on market access, ecosystem alignment, and enterprise competitiveness at district and national levels.
10:30 – 11:00	Breakaway Session 3 – Innovation, Incubation & Acceleration Examines how South Africa's MSMEs can better innovate, scale, and commercialise ideas through stronger incubation and acceleration systems. It focuses on identifying systemic barriers, improving programme design, strengthening partnerships, and expanding access to the resources required for innovation-driven growth.	Lead : SEDFA – SM: Incubation Mr Billy Bokako Moderator & Rapporteur Mr Kizito Okechukwu CEO – 22 On Sloane (TBC)	• Need for improved access to technology • Stronger incubation support • Clearer pathways for MSMEs to commercialise their ideas. • Stronger partnerships with universities, industry, and innovation hubs; • Inclusive and flexible programmes, enhanced mentorship networks, and expanded shared innovation infrastructure. • Insights will directly inform the Innovation and Capability Building components of the Ecosystem Compact.



Time	Activities	Lead	Outcomes
13:35 – 14:35 Networking Lunch • Sector-themed networking tables • Exhibition engagement continues & Promotion of MSME success stories			
14:35 – 15:05	Report Back (Plenary)	Rapporteurs	Additional Contributions to the Compact & Commitment Charter
15:05 – 15:30	Launch & Adoption of the Ecosystem Compact / Commitments Charter Purpose: To transition from dialogue to formalised, coordinated action • Formalisation of strategic partnerships • Public announcements of new initiatives • Commitment statements from ecosystem actors • Introduction of the Ecosystem Compact • Long-term collaborative framework • Stakeholder commitments to shared actions	Corporate Representative	• Adoption of a unified national framework for ecosystem collaboration. • Formalisation of new strategic partnerships and reaffirmation of existing ones. • Public commitment to joint, co designed initiatives across government, private sector, and development partners. • Strengthened accountability mechanisms through shared principles and norms. • Generation of actionable insights for 2026/27 integrated planning.
15:30 – 15:45	Closing Keynote Address • Reflections on the day • Outlook for 2026/27 • Call to action	SEDFA Board Member Mr Tembinkosi Bonakele	• Consolidated reflections on dialogue outcomes. • Call to action and clear direction for 2026/27 collaborative interventions.

Innovation - “Innovation grows where diverse ideas meet. Our ecosystem enables creativity, experimentation, and solutions that respond to real community needs.”



Time	Activities	Lead	Outcomes
15:45–16:45	Group Executives Bilateral(s) (Pre-Matched One-to-One Meetings)	SEDFA	• Targeted deal-making conversations between partners and SEDFA. • Development of a pipeline of actionable opportunities for priority sectors. • Follow-up roadmap for partnership activation post forum.
15:45 – 16:30 Exhibition Walkabout & Signing of the Commitment Charter			
18:00 – 20:00 Networking Cocktail			

Inclusion - “An inclusive ecosystem ensures that everyone has access to opportunities, resources, and the tools needed to participate meaningfully.”

